

Rejection

Everyone goes through rejection at some point, perhaps in a friendship, a relationship, or a job. Rejection hurts and can stir up a variety of emotions, but how a person handles the experience will affect how long those feelings last.

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GOOD TO KNOW

How it feels

Rejection affects people in different ways. It can be felt mildly or deeply and it can hurt emotionally or physically—it all depends on how much an individual cared for the rejector. Even if the individual doesn't have strong feelings toward the other, rejection can still be hurtful if it affects a person's confidence.

Unrequited interest

When a person is romantically or sexually interested in someone who doesn't feel the same way in return, it can cause the person to feel hurt. This can lead to feelings of not being good enough when, in reality, those two people just aren't a good match. Brain scans show that rejection and physical pain are dealt with by the same areas of the brain, which helps to explain why rejection can feel so painful.



△ Facing rejection

It's difficult, but the feelings of pain and rejection do pass with time.

Avoiding negativity

Individuals react to rejection in various ways. Some become self-critical, which can lead to feelings of low self-esteem and other negative emotions. Acknowledging and experiencing these feelings are part of the process of moving on. If the negative feelings remain, the person may need to set goals to act on and push themselves to move on.

PARENT TIPS

How to help

If your teen is hurting from a rejection, you have to follow their lead. While you want to try to make it all better, your attention may actually make them feel worse. Make sure that they know you're there for them, but don't overwhelm them with sympathy and advice. Invite your teen to do some of their favorite activities with you—but don't feel hurt if they say no.

Don't fixate

Focusing on the person who rejected you will make you feel worse, and won't help you deal with the situation. Keep your mind and body active, such as by playing music or sports.



Limit time alone

Isolating yourself can make you lose perspective and feed negative emotions. Hang out with family and friends who care about and love you—and remember, they want to spend time with you.



Redirect anger

While it is natural to feel angry when rejected, it's never okay to act on that anger by shouting at or hurting others. Doing something physical will help, such as exercise or dancing.

